

Empiricism — MCQ Questions

Philosophy Optional | Paper I | Western Philosophy | Topic 03

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MCQ QUESTION INDEX

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MCQ 1. What the empiricist rule actually asserts

Consider the following statements about British empiricism as Locke, Berkeley and Hume hold it.

1. Every simple cognitive content must be traceable to experience, which includes inner awareness of the mind's own operations.
2. The mind's operations of comparing, combining and abstracting are themselves denied, since they are not derived from sensation.
3. No proposition whatever can be known independently of experience.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 2. Locke's grounds for rejecting innate ideas

Which one of the following is not among the grounds Locke advances in Book I of the *Essay* against innate ideas?

- A. If certain ideas were innate, every human being including children would possess them, which they manifestly do not.
- B. A thought that the mind does not think is self-contradictory, since to be in the mind is to be perceived by the mind.
- C. Every idea alleged to be innate can be shown to arise instead through sensation or reflection.
- D. Innate ideas would have to be lodged in a material substratum whose nature is entirely unknown to us.

MCQ 3. Which ground does the decisive work

Locke's refutation of innate ideas is strongest against the dispositional innatism Descartes actually held only if one accepts his premise that

- A. to be in the mind is to be perceived by the mind, so an unnoticed idea is a contradiction
- B. children and the cognitively impaired demonstrably lack all of the alleged innate content
- C. the mind at birth is white paper, void of all characters, upon which experience writes
- D. every idea has in fact been traced back to some corresponding act of sensation or reflection

MCQ 4. Sorting Locke's complex ideas

Match each of Locke's three kinds of complex idea with its correct description.

1. Modes — 2. Substances — 3. Relations

I. Supposed independently existing bearers, represented through clusters of co-occurring qualities. II. Dependent combinations such as triangle, gratitude or number. III. Ideas produced by comparing one thing with another, such as cause or identity.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

A. 1–II, 2–I, 3–III

B. 1–I, 2–III, 3–II

C. 1–III, 2–II, 3–I

D. 1–II, 2–III, 3–I

MCQ 5. The three degrees of knowledge

Match each degree of Lockean knowledge with the case it certifies.

1. Intuitive — 2. Demonstrative — 3. Sensitive

I. The existence of a particular thing now affecting the senses. II. The existence of God, established through intervening ideas. III. That white is not black, seen immediately without a middle term.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

A. 1–I, 2–III, 3–II

B. 1–III, 2–II, 3–I

C. 1–II, 2–I, 3–III

D. 1–III, 2–I, 3–II

MCQ 6. Locke's account of general words

According to *Essay* III.iii, an idea becomes general when the mind

A. discovers a universal subsisting outside the mind and then forms an exact copy of it

B. selects one particular idea and resolves to let it stand for all the others of that sort

C. compares two particulars and perceives the relation that holds between them in reality

D. separates it from the circumstances of time and place and from every concomitant idea

MCQ 7. Nominal and real essence

Consider the following statements about Locke's two essences.

1. The nominal essence of gold is the abstract idea annexed to the name, such as being yellow, heavy, malleable and soluble in aqua regia.
2. The real essence is the internal constitution from which the observable properties flow, and we generally do not know it.
3. Classification of things into sorts proceeds by real essence, which is why our species divisions track nature exactly.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 8. What Locke means by a secondary quality

For Locke, the sweetness of a lump of sugar is best described as

- A. an idea existing only in the mind, with nothing at all in the sugar corresponding to it
- B. a power in the sugar, grounded in its primary-quality configuration, to produce a sensation
- C. an illusion produced by the imagination when qualities are constantly conjoined in our experience
- D. a primary quality whose resemblance to our idea is guaranteed by the principle of divine veracity

MCQ 9. The substratum in Locke

Which one of the following most accurately states Locke's position on substance at *Essay* II.xxiii.2?

- A. Substance is a self-contradictory abstraction, since being and supporting cannot be combined into any single idea at all.
- B. Substance is directly perceived by the understanding whenever a cluster of qualities is presented together in experience.
- C. Substance is a fiction of the imagination, invented only because the qualities are found to be constantly conjoined.
- D. Substance exists and supports the qualities, but we have no positive idea of its nature and merely suppose a support.

MCQ 10. The prince and the cobbler

Locke's case in which the prince's consciousness comes to inform the cobbler's body is designed to establish that

- A. the identity of a person is fixed throughout by the continued existence of the same immaterial soul
- B. bodily continuity and consciousness must always coincide in any case that could actually occur
- C. memory is merely evidential, so that neither consciousness nor the body settles who the person is
- D. personal identity follows consciousness, while the identity of the human animal follows the organism

MCQ 11. Reid's Brave Officer

The Brave Officer case is directed against Locke's criterion because it shows that

- A. a criterion built on the reach of consciousness need not be transitive, whereas identity is
- B. memories of childhood are frequently unreliable and therefore cannot ground any criterion
- C. consciousness is interrupted every night by dreamless sleep, so no person survives until morning
- D. a person may be punished for an act that he sincerely and permanently fails to remember

MCQ 12. How Locke claims to know that God exists

In Locke's classification, the existence of God is known by

- A. intuition, since the idea of a most perfect being contains existence within itself
- B. sensitive knowledge, since the order of the perceived world is immediately given
- C. demonstration, proceeding from one's own existence by way of the causal principle
- D. an innate idea implanted in every mind and elicited on reaching the age of reason

MCQ 13. What Berkeley's attack on abstraction does and does not deny

Consider the following statements about the Introduction to Berkeley's *Principles*.

1. He concedes that we can imagine a hand separately from the body, because such parts could exist apart.
2. He denies that we can frame an idea of extension without any colour or of motion without a determinate speed.
3. He concludes that general words and general reasoning are impossible and must be abandoned.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 14. Berkeley's replacement account of generality

On Berkeley's positive account, an idea is general in virtue of

- A. being made to represent or stand for all other particular ideas of the same sort
- B. having every determinate feature stripped away until only the common nature remains
- C. corresponding to a nominal essence that the understanding annexes to a sortal name
- D. being formed by the imagination out of impressions that resemble one another closely

MCQ 15. Matching Berkeley's arguments for immaterialism

Match each argument with the move that characterises it.

1. Likeness — 2. Parity — 3. Master Argument — 4. Continuity

I. Every relativity consideration Locke accepts against secondary qualities applies to primary ones too. II. The involuntary and law-governed order of sense requires an active spirit of greater power than mine. III. An idea can be like nothing but an idea, so an unperceivable original cannot be resembled. IV. You cannot conceive a body existing unconceived, because in conceiving it you conceive it.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

- A. 1–III, 2–IV, 3–I, 4–II
- B. 1–III, 2–I, 3–IV, 4–II
- C. 1–I, 2–III, 3–II, 4–IV
- D. 1–IV, 2–I, 3–III, 4–II

MCQ 16. The likeness principle and its strongest answer

The most effective reply available to a defender of Locke against the principle that "an idea can be like nothing but an idea" is that

- A. structural or mathematical correspondence needs no qualitative likeness, as a map matches terrain

- B. divine veracity guarantees that our ideas of primary qualities resemble what causes them
- C. the principle is self-refuting, since Berkeley must compare his own ideas with one another in order to state it at all
- D. resemblance between an idea and a quality is a brute relation that stands in need of no further defence whatever

MCQ 17. The Master Argument and the objection to it

The standard objection that Berkeley's Master Argument commits a scope or use–mention confusion holds that

- A. Berkeley illegitimately assumes that only spirits can be causes, which no materialist need ever concede
- B. the argument proves far too much, since it would equally show that unperceived numbers cannot exist
- C. what is inconceivable is conceiving of X that it is unconceived, not conceiving that X is unconceived
- D. conceiving a tree is a mental act, and mental acts are ideas, so the tree must itself be an idea too

MCQ 18. Spirits, notions and the work God performs

Consider the following statements about Berkeley's positive ontology.

1. Spirits are known by notion rather than by idea, because an idea is passive and could never picture an activity.
2. The laws of nature describe stable sequences in a divine language, so regularities function as signs rather than as causes.
3. Berkeley infers God from the passivity of ideas together with the involuntary and orderly arrival of sense-experience.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1, 2 and 3
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1 and 3 only

MCQ 19. Berkeley's idealism compared with Hegel's

The decisive difference between Berkeley's subjective idealism and Hegel's absolute idealism is that

- A. Berkeley denies the reality of the external world while Hegel affirms it as a moment of the Absolute
- B. Berkeley reaches idealism by dialectic while Hegel reaches it through an analysis of perception

- C. Berkeley treats matter as unknowable while Hegel treats it as fully knowable by natural science
- D. Berkeley's reality is ideas in finite and divine minds, Hegel's the self-development of Spirit

MCQ 20. Moore and Russell against Berkeley

The difference between Moore's and Russell's reactions to Berkeley is best stated by saying that

- A. Moore accepts Berkeley's premises but rejects the conclusion, whereas Russell rejects them
- B. Moore defends the ordinary object as directly known, whereas Russell replaces it with a construction
- C. Moore relies on the verification principle of meaning, whereas Russell relies on the picture theory of meaning
- D. Moore denies the act–object distinction altogether, whereas Russell insists that awareness and object are identical

MCQ 21. Impressions, ideas and the missing shade of blue

Consider the following statements about Hume's copy principle.

1. It holds that every simple idea derives from a corresponding simple impression.
2. Hume concedes the missing shade of blue as a case in which a simple idea arises without its antecedent impression.
3. The concession shows that the copy principle is an empirical generalisation rather than an analytic truth.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 1 and 3 only

MCQ 22. Placing two propositions inside Hume's fork

For Hume, the propositions " $2+2=4$ " and "The Sun will rise tomorrow" differ because

- A. the first is certain and the second is highly probable, though both are ultimately relations of ideas
- B. the first is a matter of fact whose evidence is overwhelming, the second one whose evidence is weaker
- C. the first is a relation of ideas whose denial is contradictory, the second a contingent matter of fact
- D. both are matters of fact, differing only in the number of past instances that have so far supported them

MCQ 23. Substance and the belief in body

Consider the following statements about Hume.

1. He concludes that "substance" is a fiction of the imagination, since no impression of a bearer can be found.
2. The dissolution applies to material substance only, spiritual substance being secured by inner awareness.
3. Constancy and coherence among perceptions lead the imagination to feign continued and distinct bodies.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 2 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 1 and 3 only

MCQ 24. What Hume finds and does not find in causation

In Hume's analysis, the idea of necessary connexion is copied from

- A. the observed contiguity and temporal priority of the two events considered together in one instance
- B. an innate structure of the understanding that organises perceptions
- C. an impression of reflection: the mind's felt determination to pass from cause to effect
- D. the repeated observation that gives the hundredth collision a quality which the first collision lacked

MCQ 25 (remedial). The two definitions of cause

Hume's two definitions of cause are best characterised as

- A. one objective and regularity-based, the other psychological and framed by the thought conveyed
- B. one applying only to physical events and the other exclusively to acts of the human will
- C. two equivalent formulations that Hume explicitly proves to be interchangeable in every case
- D. an earlier definition given in the *Treatise* which he then formally withdraws in the *Enquiry*

MCQ 26 (remedial). What the bundle theory denies

Hume's bundle theory of the self is correctly stated as the claim that

- A. the perceptions themselves are fictions, so that nothing whatever exists in the mind at all
- B. personal identity is constituted by the continuity of the living human organism over time
- C. the self is an active spirit whose existence is known by notion rather than by any idea
- D. there is no simple, identical self-substance, although the perceptions are entirely real

MCQ 27 (remedial). Kant's two routed replies

Match each Kantian doctrine with the Humean problem it answers.

1. Transcendental unity of apperception — 2. Second Analogy

I. The absence of any source impression for necessary connexion between events. II. The absence of any constant and invariable impression of a continuing self.

Which of the following statements is correct?

- A. 1 answers I, and 2 answers II, since apperception concerns events and the Analogy concerns the subject
- B. Neither answers a Humean problem, since Kant rejects the copy principle
- C. Both answer II, since apperception and the Analogy are two names for the same doctrine of unity
- D. 1 answers II, and 2 answers I, and in both cases Kant accepts Hume's negative finding

MCQ 28 (remedial). Where every reply to the problem of induction must strike

Kant, Popper and Strawson all direct their answers to Hume's induction dilemma at the step which asserts that

- A. all reasoning about matters of fact beyond present sense and memory rests on cause and effect
- B. the Uniformity Principle can be established only demonstratively or probably, by no third route
- C. the denial of the Uniformity Principle implies no contradiction and is therefore perfectly conceivable
- D. any experiential argument for the Uniformity Principle already presupposes that very principle

MCQ 29 (remedial). Two sentences that must never be written

Consider the following two statements.

- 1. Berkeley denies the existence of the external world.
- 2. Hume denies causation.

Which of the following corrects both?

- A. Berkeley denies only unperceived objects, while Hume denies only that causes precede their effects
- B. Berkeley denies sensible things but keeps spirits; Hume denies causal inference but keeps conjunction
- C. Berkeley denies material substance but keeps sensible things; Hume denies objective necessity only
- D. Both statements are accurate summaries of the two positions and are safe to use in an examination

MCQ 30 (remedial). Provenance and dating

Consider the following statements about the texts of this syllabus item.

1. "*Tabula rasa*" is Locke's own phrase in the *Essay*.
2. "*Esse est percipi aut percipere*" is Berkeley's own Latin in the *Principles*.
3. The chapter on personal identity was added to the *Essay* in the second edition of 1694.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- A. 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 2 and 3 only

MCQ 31 (remedial). What this syllabus item does not own

Which one of the following belongs to this syllabus item rather than to another owner?

- A. Quine's argument in "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" against the analytic–synthetic distinction
- B. Kant's transcendental exposition of space and time together with his table of the categories
- C. Hume's account of why we believe in continued bodies despite interrupted perception
- D. Hegel's dialectical method and the movement of determinate negation towards the Absolute

MCQ 32 (remedial). What a comparative answer in this item must contain

A twenty-mark comparative answer on Locke, Berkeley and Hume earns its marks primarily by

- A. narrating each philosopher's system in turn and closing with a paragraph of general observations
- B. announcing a single criterion, running matched axes, and ruling on the sequence it produces
- C. reproducing the chronology of publication so that the historical influences are fully displayed
- D. listing every objection raised against each thinker without adjudicating between them

MCQ 33. Locke's decisive premise and dispositional innatism

Consider the following statements about Locke's argument against innate ideas.

1. The absence of conscious assent directly defeats an innatism on which the relevant content is occurrent from birth.
2. A Cartesian may instead call an idea innate as a native disposition whose content becomes explicit only when suitable experience occasions it.
3. If Locke excludes this reply simply by defining whatever is "in the mind" as presently perceived, the disputed anti-innatist conclusion has entered his premise.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 1 and 3 only

MCQ 34. The ordered components of Humean causation

A candidate analyses a cause as "an event regularly conjoined with a nearby event" but omits both the direction of succession and the mind's acquired transition. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Add temporal priority to distinguish cause from effect, then distinguish repeated constant conjunction from the felt determination that supplies the idea of necessity.
- B. Add simultaneity to distinguish cause from effect, then locate necessity in a quality newly acquired by the repeatedly observed objects.
- C. Replace contiguity with resemblance, because resembling events alone generate an inference from one member of the pair to the other.
- D. Remove constant conjunction, because one observed instance already contains the necessary power that repetition merely makes more vivid.

MCQ 35. Isomorphism as a defence of representative realism

Consider the following claims made in defence of Locke against Berkeley's likeness principle.

1. A representation may preserve relations among features without sharing their sensible qualities, as a map preserves spatial structure without being terrain-coloured.
2. Such structural isomorphism answers the objection that an idea can literally resemble only another idea.
3. The defence preserves representative realism only in a weakened form, because correspondence and a reliable route to its external relatum must still be established.

Which of the claims given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

MCQ 36. Berkeley's God and public objectivity

Two observers leave a room and later return to find its sensible order stable and mutually confirmable. On Berkeley's principles, the best explanation is that

- A. each observer privately recreates the same object by memory, and agreement is an unexplained coincidence
- B. the ideas of sense belong to a stable divine order, so finite observers encounter law-governed public regularities rather than self-authored private worlds
- C. an unperceived material substratum preserves the object while no spirit perceives it and later produces matching ideas
- D. sensible things cease absolutely between perceptions, while scientific laws concern only verbal conventions imposed afterward

MCQ 37. The Appendix problem inside the bundle theory

Consider the following statements about Hume's Appendix confession.

1. The bundle theory rejects a simple identical self-substance while retaining the reality of the successive perceptions.
2. Resemblance and causation explain why imagination ascribes identity, but they do not by themselves provide a real bearer or necessary bond among perceptions.
3. Hume's inability to state a satisfactory principle of union raises the possibility that atomically distinct perceptions cannot generate the unity the theory must explain.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 1 and 3 only

MCQ 38. What custom explains and what it does not justify

A person expects bread to nourish tomorrow because repeated conjunction has made the transition from one idea to the other unavoidable. Which assessment is Humean without overstating Hume's result?

- A. The expectation is rationally demonstrated because a sufficiently long sequence makes a change in nature contradictory.
- B. The expectation is probably justified by past uniformity without circularity, since probability does not itself presuppose causal reasoning.
- C. The expectation is groundless even as a psychological fact, because Hume's scepticism prevents the mind from forming beliefs.
- D. Custom explains why the expectation occurs and makes it practically unavoidable, but it does not supply a non-circular rational justification of induction.

MCQ 39. The limit of an empiricist origin rule

Consider the following statements about the thesis that cognitive content originates in experience.

1. It does not entail that every truth is known a posteriori, because Hume's relations of ideas are knowable by thought and their denials are contradictory.
2. Tracing the constituent ideas of a proposition to impressions does not by itself explain the proposition's necessity or universality.
3. An origin rule for simple ideas therefore cannot, without further argument, serve as a complete theory of a priori truth.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1, 2 and 3
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1 and 3 only

MCQ 40. Berkeley and Hume on scientific order

Consider the following statements comparing Berkeley and Hume.

1. Berkeley preserves stable, intersubjective scientific order by treating natural laws as regular signs in the divine language of ideas.
2. Hume preserves expectation and prediction through observed regularity and custom while withholding rationally perceived objective necessity.
3. Both can retain practical scientific order, but neither thereby restores necessary efficient connections among sensible events as ordinarily conceived.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 2 and 3 only

MCQ 41. From Humean custom to Kantian necessity

With reference to the 2026 question on Hume's ideas of reason and Kant's response, which one of the following gives the most defensible comparison?

- A. Hume and Kant offer the same answer because both make causal necessity a subjective habit acquired from repeated experience and deny it objective validity.
- B. Hume explains felt expectation through custom; Kant treats rule-governed causality as a synthetic a priori condition of objective experience, so custom does not answer Kant's question of right.
- C. Hume establishes causal necessity for things in themselves, whereas Kant restricts causality to associative expectations within finite subjects.
- D. Kant rejects Hume's account of conjunction and derives both the category of cause and every particular causal law independently of experience.